

Copyright The exclusive legal right to reproduce, sell, or distribute an original creative work, usually for a fixed number of years.

Corporation An independent legal entity, owned by shareholders, that is authorized to conduct business.

Counsel 1) A *barrister*. 2) A lawyer appointed to give legal advice or to represent a client in a *court* of law.

Court An institution or body of people with the authority to hear and resolve legal disputes. Also, a place where legal disputes are heard.

Covenant 1) A binding written agreement that can be enforced in a *court* of law. 2) (biblical) A binding agreement based on faithful loyalty between God and His people.

Crimes against humanity A deliberate, systematic, and widespread attack on a civilian population. Examples include murder, rape, and torture.

Criminal law The branch of law by which the *state* punishes those who have committed the most serious kind of wrong.

Cybercrime Criminal activities carried out using a computer or the internet.

Damages Money awarded by a *court* to a party that has suffered loss or injury as a result of another party's wrongful act.

Decriminalization Removing or reducing legal penalties for an act.

Defendant A person or organization accused in a *court* of law.

Defense The process of presenting *evidence* in an attempt to prove that a *defendant* is innocent.

Democracy A form of government in which supreme power is vested in the people or exercised by their elected representatives.

Direct democracy Government by the people in fact rather than merely in principle—*citizens* vote on every issue affecting them.

Discrimination The unfair and prejudicial treatment of a person or group of people based on factors such as race, gender, religion, disability, social class, or sexuality.

Divine right of kings A doctrine that held that a monarch derived legitimacy from God and was not subject to any earthly authority.

DNA Deoxyribonucleic acid. A large molecule that carries unique genetic information and so can be used to identify any individual.

Due process The carrying out of legal proceedings according to established rules and principles that ensure people are treated fairly and their legal rights are respected.

Edict An official proclamation, command, or instruction issued by someone in authority.

Election A formal process in which a population (the electorate) of a country, *state*, or local area votes for an individual to hold a position of public office.

Embargo A government order to cease trade or other commercial activity with a particular country, often used as a diplomatic measure.

Enlightenment, The A period also known as the Age of Reason, spanning 1685–1815, when European thinkers questioned established ideas on religion and authority and promoted ideals such as liberty, progress, and tolerance.

Evidence Information presented at a *court*, *hearing*, or *trial* to help a *judge* or *jury* reach a *verdict*.

Executive The branch of government that is responsible for seeing that laws and policies are implemented and enforced.

Extradition The return of a person accused of a crime to the *state* or country where the crime was said to have been committed.

Federal Describes any political system where there is an overall central government (federal government), but with many areas of decision-making being carried out by regional governments—for example, governments of provinces or *states*; the division of powers between the federal and regional governments is normally guaranteed by a *constitution*.

Felony A crime regarded by many legal systems as more serious than a minor misdemeanor.

Feudal Describes a medieval political, social, economic, and military system where a country's monarch ruled at the top of a pyramidlike hierarchy. Each level of society was entitled to claim rights from those "below," but also obliged to undertake duties to those "above."

Fraud Criminal deception to secure financial or personal gain.